FAITHFUL TO THE END

Small-group kit

Four sessions for home groups and small groups – one per chapter, 75 to 90 minutes each. Each session builds on the devotionals.

SESSION 1	Not Ashamed	2 Timothy 1:1–18
SESSION 2	Strengthened by Grace	2 Timothy 2:1–26
SESSION 3	Remain in the Word	2 Timothy 3:1–17
SESSION 4	Finish the Race	2 Timothy 4:1–22

Scripture: own translation from the Greek by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Base text: SBL Greek New Testament, © 2010 Society of Biblical Literature and Logos Bible Software (CC BY 4.0).

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SESSION 1 · 2 TIMOTHY 1:1–18

Not Ashamed

THE BIG IDEA

God did not give us a spirit of cowardice: because Christ has broken the power of death and God guards what is entrusted, we can rekindle his gift and stand unashamed with the gospel and with his suffering people.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a campfire or a fireplace that had almost gone out. What did it take to get it burning again?

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:1–18

Read in three parts with three readers: verses 1–7 (Paul's greeting and the gift of God), verses 8–14 (not ashamed of the gospel – read verse 12 slowly), verses 15–18 (those who turned away, and Onesiphorus).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul is in chains in Rome, around AD 66–67, under the emperor Nero, and he is expecting his execution. This is his last letter – written to his "beloved child" Timothy in Ephesus, who is under heavy pressure and tempted to shrink back. Tonight we read chapter 1: a gift that needs to be rekindled, a gospel we need not be ashamed of, and two very different ways of responding to an apostle in chains.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***anazōpyreō* – ἀναζωπυρέω** "rekindle": A verb found only here in the New Testament: ana (again), zōos (alive), pyr (fire) – bellows worked over smouldering coals until the ash blows away. Timothy's gift is not dead, but fear and tears have let a layer of ash settle over it (1:6).
- ***epaischynomai* – ἐπαισχύνομαι** "be ashamed": The key word of 1:8–18 occurs three times: as a call to Timothy (v. 8), as Paul's own testimony (v. 12), and as the badge of honour of Onesiphorus, who "was not ashamed of my chain" (v. 16).
- ***parathēkē* – παραθήκη** "my entrusted deposit": A banking and legal term for something handed over for safekeeping. In 1:12 the Greek leaves open whether it is what Paul has entrusted to God or what God has entrusted to Paul; in 1:14 it is clearly the sound teaching entrusted to Timothy.

DISCUSSION

1. Paul is in chains and expecting death, yet he opens with "the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus" and with gratitude. What does that tell you about where his hope is anchored? (2 Timothy 1:1–5)
2. Timothy's faith "lived first in your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice". Who passed the faith on to you – and why does Paul add "it lives in you as well"? (2 Timothy 1:5)
3. "Rekindle the gift of God" – the gift is under ash, not dead. What kinds of "ash" settle on our faith and our gifts today? (2 Timothy 1:6)
4. Verse 7 names a "spirit of cowardice" – not natural caution, but shrinking back from what God calls us to. Where do we hide fear behind good excuses? What would power, love and self-control look like instead? (2 Timothy 1:7)

5. Read verses 9–10 again. How does knowing that grace was given to us “before eternal ages” and that Christ “broke the power of death” give us courage to stand up for the gospel? (2 Timothy 1:8–10)
6. “I know whom I have believed.” Paul's confidence rests on a Person, not only on facts. What difference does that make when you are under pressure? (2 Timothy 1:12)
7. Phygelus and Hermogenes turned away; Onesiphorus “searched hard for me and found me”. Who in your world is “chained” by illness, loss or loneliness – and what would it take to be an Onesiphorus to them? (2 Timothy 1:15–18)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one layer of “ash” on your faith or your gifts this week and take one practical step to fan the flame again – prayer, opening the Scriptures, or using a gift you have let lie.
- Be an Onesiphorus: seek out one person who is going through a hard season – visit, call or write – and refresh them.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 7 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank God for the people who passed the faith on to you, name one place where fear holds you back, and ask for his power, love and self-control. Close by praying for people you know who are “chained” by hardship.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 1–2). Chapter 1 is rich; choose four or five questions and leave time for the last one.
- 1:12 “my entrusted deposit”: our translation deliberately leaves this open. It may mean what Paul has entrusted to God (his life, his ministry, his future) or what God has entrusted to Paul (the gospel, as in 1:14). Both readings bring comfort – don't let the question become the main topic of the evening.
- Some in the group had no Lois or Eunice, or grieve over children or grandchildren who have left the faith. Handle this gently: Paul's point is that faith must become personal – “it lives in you as well” – and God also uses spiritual parents and mentors.
- Verse 7 can sound like an accusation to people who struggle with anxiety. The day 1 devotional distinguishes deilia (cowardice: shrinking back from God's call) from natural caution, and says fear is overcome not by willpower alone but by the fullness of the Spirit. Don't let the verse become a verdict on anyone's struggles.
- Background: in Rome's honour-and-shame culture, standing with a condemned prisoner could cost your reputation, your property and even your freedom. Help the group find today's equivalents without letting the evening turn into complaints about the culture.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 2 – the soldier, the athlete and the farmer, and the sentence “But the word of God is not chained.”

Related devotionals: Day 1 – Rekindle the Gift of God · Day 2 – Do Not Be Ashamed of the Testimony

2 Timothy 1:1–18

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, in keeping with the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus, [2] to Timothy, my beloved child: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

[3] I am grateful to God, whom I serve with a clear conscience as my forefathers did, when I remember you without ceasing in my prayers, night and day. [4] I long to see you – I remember your tears – so that I may be filled with joy, [5] for I have been reminded of the sincere faith that is in you, a faith that lived first in your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice, and I am convinced that it lives in you as well. [6] For this reason I remind you to rekindle the gift of God that is in you through the laying on of my hands. [7] For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of power and of love and of self-control.

[8] Do not be ashamed, then, of the testimony about our Lord or of me, his prisoner; rather, share in hardship for the gospel, in the power of God, [9] who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not on the basis of our works but on the basis of his own purpose and grace, which was given to us in Christ Jesus before eternal ages, [10] but has now been revealed through the appearing of our Saviour Jesus Christ, who broke the power of death and brought life and imperishability to light through the gospel, [11] for which I was appointed a herald and an apostle and a teacher. [12] That is why I am suffering these things too; but I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard my entrusted deposit until that day. [13] Hold to the example of sound words that you heard from me, in the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. [14] Guard the precious thing that has been entrusted to you, through the Holy Spirit who lives in us.

[15] You know that all who are in the province of Asia have turned away from me, among them Phygelus and Hermogenes. [16] May the Lord grant mercy to the household of Onesiphorus, for he often refreshed me and was not ashamed of my chain. [17] On the contrary, when he came to Rome, he searched hard for me and found me – [18] may the Lord grant him to find mercy from the Lord on that day! – and you know better than I do how much he served in Ephesus.

SESSION 2 · 2 TIMOTHY 2:1–26

Strengthened by Grace

THE BIG IDEA

Strengthened by grace and remembering the risen Christ, we pass the unchained word on to faithful people, handle it accurately and meet even our opponents with gentleness – because he remains faithful.

TO GET STARTED

Who taught you a skill – cooking, a trade, a sport – that you have since passed on to someone else?

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:1–26

Read in three parts with three readers: verses 1–7 (soldier, athlete, farmer), verses 8–13 (read the hymn in verses 11–13 together, line by line), verses 14–26 (the approved worker and the servant of the Lord).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 1 ended with people who turned away and one faithful friend; chapter 2 opens with "You then, my child" – Timothy must stand firm. Paul knows his life will soon end, and his question is how the gospel will go forward when he is no longer there. Tonight we read three pictures of endurance, the unchained word with a hymn of God's faithfulness, and instructions for dealing with false teaching in the church – Hymenaeus and Philetus were saying that the resurrection had already taken place.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***endynamou* – ἐνδυναμοῦ** "be strengthened": Present tense and usually understood as passive (2:1): keep on letting yourself be made strong by the grace that is in Christ Jesus. Strength is not generated from within; it is received from Christ's grace.
- ***orthotomeō* – ὀρθοτομέω** "handle accurately": Found only here in the New Testament, literally "cutting straight" – a stonemason, a ploughman's furrow, a straight road, or Paul the tentmaker cutting along a pattern. False teachers cut Scripture crooked; the approved worker is one "who handles the word of truth accurately" (2:15).
- ***skeuos eis timēn* – σκεῦος εἰς τιμήν** "a vessel meant for honour": In a large house some vessels serve at the table, others carry out the waste (2:20). But unlike a clay pot, anyone who purifies himself "will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master" (2:21). Purity, not status, makes us useful.

DISCUSSION

1. Paul says "be strengthened by the grace". What is the difference between trying to be strong for God in our own strength and letting his grace make us strong? (2 Timothy 2:1)
2. Verse 2 describes four generations: Paul, Timothy, "faithful people" and "others". Why does Paul look first for faithful people rather than brilliant ones? Whose life are you investing in? (2 Timothy 2:2)
3. Soldier, athlete, farmer: undivided focus, no shortcuts, patient hard work. Which of the three pictures speaks to you most right now – and why? (2 Timothy 2:3–7)
4. "Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead." When problems fill your whole field of vision, what helps you keep the risen Christ before your eyes? (2 Timothy 2:8)

5. Paul is chained “like a criminal”, “but the word of God is not chained”. Where do you feel limited or “chained” – and how might God's word still move through you? (2 Timothy 2:9)
6. Read the hymn in verses 11–13 again. Which line comforts you, and which line warns you? What does “he remains faithful” mean to you on a weak day? (2 Timothy 2:11–13)
7. Verses 24–26: a servant of the Lord must not quarrel, but be kind, patient when wronged, and correct with gentleness. Think of someone who opposes your faith. What would gentleness look like in your next conversation? (2 Timothy 2:24–26)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one of the “faithful people” around you – a younger colleague, a child or grandchild, someone new to faith – and arrange a coffee in the next two weeks to open the Scriptures and pray together.
- Each morning this week, before you look at your phone, read 2:8 and tell yourself: “Remember Jesus Christ.” Then name one situation in which you will trust his unchained word.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read the hymn of 2:11–13 aloud together. Then pray in threes: for strength from grace in a place where you feel exhausted, for the faithful people you want to invest in, and with gentleness for someone who opposes the faith – that God may grant them repentance that leads to the knowledge of the truth.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (days 3–5) and the whole of chapter 2. Don't try to cover everything: choose one question from each section (vv. 1–7, 8–13, 14–26) and add others as time allows.
- Verses 11–13: our translation keeps the future tense in 12b (“if we will deny him”) and leaves open whether verse 13 is a warning or a comfort. The day 4 devotional mentions both and stresses the comfort for the weak; 12b means a final, persistent rejection of Christ, not a stumble like Peter's that ends in repentance. If someone fears they have “denied” Christ, point them to verse 13 and offer to talk afterwards.
- Verse 18: Hymenaeus and Philetus taught that the resurrection had already taken place – probably only as an inner, spiritual awakening, with no future bodily resurrection (day 5). Hymenaeus is very probably the man of 1 Timothy 1:20.
- Verse 22 “desires of youth”: the day 5 devotional includes sexual temptation but also the urges of an immature spirit – impatience, opinionatedness, the urge to win every argument, a quick temper, pride. Keep this in view so that the verse is not heard as being only about sex or only about the young.
- Verse 26 is open in the Greek: whose will is meant (“for his will”) – the devil's or God's? Our translation leaves it open; you don't need to decide.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 3 – difficult times in the last days, and the Scripture that is God-breathed.

Related devotionals: Day 3 – Strengthened by Grace: Soldier, Athlete and Farmer · Day 4 – The Word of God Is Not Chained · Day 5 – An Approved Worker and a Vessel for Honour

2 Timothy 2:1–26

[1] You then, my child, be strengthened by the
grace that is in Christ Jesus. [2] And the things
you heard from me through many witnesses –
entrust these to faithful people who will be
competent to teach others too. [3] Share in hard-
ship as a good soldier of Christ Jesus. [4] No one
serving as a soldier gets entangled in the affairs
of everyday life, since he wants to please the
one who enlisted him. [5] Likewise, anyone who
competes as an athlete is not crowned unless he
competes according to the rules. [6] The farmer
who works hard ought to be the first to receive
a share of the crops. [7] Think about what I am
saying, for the Lord will give you understand-
ing in everything.

[8] Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead,
descended from David, according to my gospel.
[9] For this gospel I am enduring hardship, even
to the point of being chained like a criminal.
But the word of God is not chained. [10] That is
why I endure all things for the sake of the cho-
sen, so that they too may obtain the salvation
that is in Christ Jesus, with eternal glory. [11] This
is a trustworthy saying:

For if we died with him,
we will also live with him;
[12] if we endure,
we will also reign with him;
if we will deny him,
he also will deny us;
[13] if we are faithless,
he remains faithful –
for he cannot deny himself.

[14] Keep reminding them of these things, and
solemnly charge them before the Lord not to
fight about words; it is of no use and only ruins
those who listen. [15] Make every effort to present
yourself to God as approved, a worker with
nothing to be ashamed of, who handles the
word of truth accurately. [16] But avoid irrever-
ent, empty chatter, for those who indulge in it
will advance further and further into ungodli-
ness, [17] and their talk will spread like gangrene.
Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus,
[18] who have missed the mark concerning the
truth by saying that the resurrection has al-
ready taken place, and they are overturning the
faith of some. [19] Yet the solid foundation laid by
God stands firm, and it bears this seal: "The
Lord knows who are his," and: "Everyone who
names the name of the Lord must turn away
from wrongdoing."

[20] In a large house you find not only vessels of
gold and silver, but also vessels of wood and
clay – some meant for honour, others for dis-
honour. [21] So if anyone purifies himself from
these, he will be a vessel meant for honour –
consecrated, useful to the master, prepared for
every good work. [22] Flee from the desires of
youth, and pursue righteousness, faith, love
and peace, together with those who call on the
Lord out of a pure heart. [23] Refuse foolish and
uninstructed controversies, knowing that they
give rise to quarrels. [24] And a servant of the
Lord must not quarrel, but be kind to everyone,
able to teach, patient when wronged, [25] in-
structing with gentleness those who oppose
him, in the hope that God may grant them re-
pentance that leads to the knowledge of the
truth, [26] and they will come to their senses and
escape from the trap of the devil, having been
taken captive by him for his will.

SESSION 3 · 2 TIMOTHY 3:1–17

Remain in the Word

THE BIG IDEA

In difficult times an outward form of godliness is not enough; what keeps us standing is the God-breathed Scripture, learned from people whose lives we have seen up close.

TO GET STARTED

Who taught you something important – not in a classroom, but by letting you watch how they lived? What did you pick up from them?

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 3:1–17

Use two readers: verses 1–9 (the warning – read the list at a steady pace and pause after "Turn away from such people!") and verses 10–17 (the answer); then read verses 16–17 aloud together.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 2 Paul told Timothy to treat the misled with gentleness and patience. Now he warns him not to be naive: the "last days" – the whole period between Christ's first coming and his return – bring difficult times, even inside the church. Tonight we read chapter 3: a portrait of religion that is only an outer shell, and Paul's answer – a life lived in the open and the Scriptures breathed out by God.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***philautoi … philotheoi* – φίλαυτοι … φιλόθεοι** "lovers of themselves … lovers of God": Paul frames the list with words built on *philos* (love): it begins with "lovers of themselves" and ends with "lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God" (3:2, 4). The root of the decay is disordered love – when love of self pushes out love of God, relationships fall apart.
- ***morphōsis eusebeias* – μόρφωσις εὐσεβείας** "outward form of godliness": A *morphōsis* is an outward form or shell. These people are "having an outward form of godliness but denying its power" (3:5): the right words and the right meetings, but no *dynamis* – no power of the Spirit that changes the heart.
- ***theopneustos* – θεόπνευστος** "God-breathed": The word occurs only here in the New Testament (3:16): Scripture is breathed out by God. When Scripture speaks, God speaks – and so it is useful "for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness".

DISCUSSION

1. Read the list in verses 2–4 again. Which of these marks do you recognise most in our culture today? Why might the list begin with "lovers of themselves"? (2 Timothy 3:1–4)
2. Paul is describing people who are "having an outward form of godliness but denying its power". What could that look like in a church – and, honestly, in my own life? (2 Timothy 3:5)
3. "always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth" – how is it possible to take in many sermons, podcasts and books and still not change? (2 Timothy 3:7)
4. Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses by imitating his miracles. Where do we meet imitations of true faith today, and how can we tell the difference? (2 Timothy 3:8–9)

5. Timothy had closely followed Paul's life – including what happened in Lystra, probably his home town. Who has let you see their faith up close? And who is watching yours? (2 Timothy 3:10–11)
6. “all who want to live in godliness in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.” Do we expect the Christian life to be comfortable? What has following Christ cost you? (2 Timothy 3:12)
7. Scripture is useful “for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness”. Which of these four do you welcome easily – and which do you tend to avoid? (2 Timothy 3:16–17)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Take one Bible passage each day this week and ask four questions: What does it teach me? Where does it reprove me? What does it want to set straight? How does it train me in righteousness?
- Spend time this week with someone younger in faith – a child, a grandchild or a new believer – and tell them about one time when God carried you through something hard.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of silence, asking God to show you any area where you are content with an outward form. Then pray together: thank God for his God-breathed Word, for the parents, grandparents and mentors who passed it on to you, and pray for the children and young people in your lives.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 6 and 7). The list in verses 2–4 easily turns into complaining about “the world out there”; day 6 aims the sharpest question at “us who sit in the pews” – steer the group there.
- Handle 3:6 (“weak women”, *gynaikaria*) with care. Following day 6, it is a judgment on these particular people who let themselves be taken in, not on women in general. The ones under judgment are the false teachers; the people they prey on are “weighed down with sins and driven by all kinds of desires” – a weakness any of us can have.
- Our translation reads 3:16 predicatively: “All Scripture is God-breathed and useful”. Day 7 notes that the reading every God-breathed Scripture is also useful is grammatically possible; our translation follows the more common reading. Mention it if asked, but don't let it take over.
- Verse 15 (“from childhood”) may be painful for those without a Christian upbringing, or for parents whose children have turned away. It is never too late to sow the Word – say so gently.
- If time is short, skip question 4. Point ahead: next week is the last session – chapter 4, Paul's final charge and his last words. Consider ending it with a meal or a longer time of prayer.

Related devotionals: Day 6 – Difficult Times and a Show of Godliness · Day 7 – Persevere in the Holy, God-Breathed Scriptures

2 Timothy 3:1–17

1 But understand this: in the last days difficult
times will come. 2 For people will be lovers of
themselves, lovers of money, boastful, arro-
gant, blasphemers, disobedient to their par-
ents, ungrateful, unholy, 3 heartless, irreconcil-
able, slanderers, without self-restraint, brutal,
haters of what is good, 4 treacherous, reckless,
puffed up, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers
of God, 5 having an outward form of godliness
but denying its power. Turn away from such
people! 6 For among them are those who worm
their way into households and take captive
weak women, who are weighed down with sins
and driven by all kinds of desires, 7 always
learning and never able to come to the knowl-
edge of the truth. 8 Just as Jannes and Jambres
opposed Moses, so these also oppose the truth:
people corrupted in mind, who have failed the
test regarding the faith. 9 But they will not get
very far, for their folly will become plain to ev-
eryone, as happened with those two.

10 You, however, have closely followed my
teaching, my way of life, my purpose, my faith,
my patience, my love, my endurance, 11 my per-
secutions and my sufferings, the things that
happened to me in Antioch, in Iconium and in
Lystra. What persecutions I bore! And the Lord
rescued me from all of them. 12 Indeed, all who
want to live in godliness in Christ Jesus will be
persecuted. 13 But evil people and impostors
will go from bad to worse, deceiving and being
deceived. 14 But you, remain in what you have
learned and have become convinced of, know-
ing from whom you learned it, 15 and that from
childhood you have known the sacred writings,
which can give you the wisdom that leads to
salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. 16 All
Scripture is God-breathed and useful for teach-
ing, for reproof, for correction, for training in
righteousness, 17 so that the man of God may be
fully capable, equipped for every good work.

SESSION 4 · 2 TIMOTHY 4:1–22

Finish the Race

THE BIG IDEA

Because Scripture is God's voice and Christ is the coming Judge, we proclaim the word whether the time is right or not – and when everyone else leaves, the Lord stands by his servant and brings him safely home.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a finish line you have crossed – a race, an exam, a big project, a long journey. What kept you going near the end?

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:1–22

Use three readers: verses 1–5 (the charge – firmly, like a herald), verses 6–8 (Paul's testimony – slowly), verses 9–22 (requests and greetings – let the names stand). Close by reading verse 22 aloud together.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul is in chains in Rome, probably around AD 66 or 67; winter is coming and he knows his death is near. Chapter 4 holds the last words we have from his pen: a solemn charge to Timothy, a look back on his finished race, and very personal requests and greetings. Tonight we close the series with Paul's last words.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***kēryxon ton logon* – κήρυξον τὸν λόγον** "proclaim the word": A *kēryx* was a herald who announced the King's decree in the town square – not his own philosophy. His one duty was faithfulness to the message of the one who sent him, "whether the time is right or not" (4:2).
- ***spendomai / analysis* – σπένδομαι / ἀνάλυσις** "poured out as a drink offering … departure": "For already I am being poured out as a drink offering" (4:6): Paul sees his execution not as a wasted life but as a last offering of worship. *Analysis* was used of loosing a ship's mooring ropes – death as setting sail for home.
- ***ho de kyrios moi parestē* – ὁ δὲ κύριός μοι παρέστη** "the Lord stood by me": *Paristēmi* means to come and stand right beside someone – in court, like an advocate beside the accused. When no one stood by Paul, "the Lord stood by me and gave me strength" (4:17).

DISCUSSION

1. Paul gives his charge "before God and Christ Jesus, who is going to judge the living and the dead". How does living before the coming King change the way we speak and serve? (2 Timothy 4:1–2)
2. People "will pile up teachers for themselves because their ears itch". Where are we tempted to listen only to what we want to hear? How do you react when the Word reproves you? (2 Timothy 4:3–4)
3. "I have fought the good fight, I have run the race to the end, I have kept the faith." The crown is for "all who have loved his appearing". What does it look like to love Christ's appearing in everyday life? (2 Timothy 4:7–8)
4. Demas "loved this present age"; Mark, who once deserted Paul, is now "useful to me for service". What do these two stories say to someone who started strong – and to someone who has failed? (2 Timothy 4:10–11)

5. About Alexander Paul says “the Lord will repay him according to his works”; about those who left him, “may it not be counted against them!” How does Paul handle people who hurt him? Is there someone you need to leave with God or forgive? (2 Timothy 4:14–16)
6. When have you known that the Lord stood by you when people could not or would not? Share only what you are comfortable sharing. (2 Timothy 4:17–18)
7. As we finish 2 Timothy: which verse from these four chapters will you take with you, and why?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of a “Mark” – someone who has failed or drifted and feels written off. Contact them this week with a word of encouragement.
- Choose one verse from 2 Timothy as your verse for the road, learn it by heart, and tell one person why you chose it.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God that the Lord stood by Paul and stands by us. Pray for people who stand alone right now – in a hospital room, a courtroom or at a grave. Then read 4:18 aloud together: “The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and will save me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory for ever and ever. Amen.” The leader closes with 4:22 as a blessing.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This is the last session of the series. Keep about ten minutes for the closing question (question 7) and the prayer; a shared meal afterwards suits the occasion.
- The chapter has two halves (days 8 and 9). Don't skip the personal requests and greetings in verses 9–22 – there the gospel becomes very personal: the cloak, the parchments, Trophimus left sick.
- 4:14 is a statement, not a curse: “the Lord will repay him”. Following day 9, Paul does not take revenge but leaves the matter with God – and in verse 16 he prays for those who abandoned him.
- Talk of death (vv. 6–8) and of being abandoned (v. 16) may touch people who are grieving, lonely or have been let down. Allow silence with question 6 and don't press anyone to share.
- Avoid speculating about people from your church who have “left” when discussing Demas. End with Mark: past failure is never final with God.

Related devotionals: Day 8 – Proclaim the Word and Finish the Race · Day 9 – Alone in the Dungeon, but the Lord Stands by Me

2 Timothy 4:1–22

1 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ
Jesus, who is going to judge the living and the
dead, and by his appearing and his kingdom:
2 proclaim the word; keep at it whether the time
is right or not; reprove, rebuke, encourage,
with all patience and teaching. 3 For the time
will come when people will not put up with
sound teaching, but, following their own de-
sires, will pile up teachers for themselves be-
cause their ears itch, 4 and they will turn their
ears away from the truth and wander off to
myths. 5 But you, be sober-minded in every-
thing, endure hardship, do the work of an
evangelist, carry out your service fully.

6 For already I am being poured out as a drink
offering, and the time for my departure is here.
7 I have fought the good fight, I have run the
race to the end, I have kept the faith. 8 What re-
mains is this: the crown of righteousness is
stored up for me, which the Lord, the righteous
judge, will give me on that day – and not to me
only, but to all who have loved his appearing.

9 Make every effort to come to me soon. 10 For
Demas has abandoned me, because he loved
this present age, and has gone to Thessalonica;
Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia.
11 Only Luke is with me. Pick up Mark and bring
him along, for he is useful to me for service. 12 I
have sent Tychicus to Ephesus. 13 When you
come, bring the cloak that I left with Carpus in
Troas, and the books, especially the parch-
ments. 14 Alexander the metalworker did me
much harm – the Lord will repay him according
to his works. 15 You too must be on your guard
against him, for he strongly opposed our
words.

16 At my first defence no one stood by me, but all
abandoned me – may it not be counted against
them! 17 But the Lord stood by me and gave me
strength, so that through me the proclamation
might be fully carried out and all the nations
might hear it; and I was rescued from the
mouth of the lion. 18 The Lord will rescue me
from every evil deed and will save me for his
heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory for ever
and ever. Amen.

19 Greet Prisca and Aquila and the household of
Onesiphorus. 20 Erastus stayed in Corinth, and I
left Trophimus sick in Miletus. 21 Make every ef-
fort to come before winter. Eubulus greets you,
as do Pudens and Linus and Claudia and all the
brothers and sisters.

22 The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with
you all.